Super Sunday: A Case for Public Investment

Data-Driven Analysis of Super Sunday's Economic Impact and Cultural Value

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On behalf of the New Orleans Mardi Gras Indian Council

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Summary of Event and Findings

On March 16, 2025, over 34,000 people gathered to celebrate Super Sunday, the annual showcase of New Orleans' Mardi Gras Indian culture. Our analysis reveals something remarkable: this community-organized event delivers exceptional economic returns while preserving an irreplaceable 200-year tradition. The 2025 event cost $70,000 and generated $296,155 in direct tax revenue—a 4.23x return. The event created $4.2 million in total economic impact while serving predominantly underrepresented communities with 100% free admission. Super Sunday isn't just economically efficient—it's irreplaceable. The Mardi Gras Indian tradition exists nowhere else in the world. This is the kind of asset that makes New Orleans unique and economically viable as a tourism destination.

Event Attendance

Our analysis, based on Louisiana cultural festival spending patterns, estimates visitors spent $2.64 million on March 16. Local attendees—18,000 people—spent approximately $35 per person on food, beverages, and incidentals, totaling $630,000. Non-local visitors—16,100 people—spent approximately $125 per person on food, lodging, transportation, and retail, totaling $2,012,500. These spending estimates are deliberately conservative, drawn from peer-reviewed Louisiana cultural economy studies representing the lower end of documented spending ranges for similar events.

Money doesn't stop at the first transaction. When a visitor buys lunch at a local restaurant, that restaurant purchases supplies from vendors, pays employee wages, and those employees spend their earnings locally. Using a conservative 1.6x multiplier—peer-reviewed studies of Louisiana cultural festivals show multipliers of 1.5 to 1.9x—Super Sunday's $2.64 million in direct spending generated $4.2 million in total economic impact. Statistical analysis using bootstrap resampling indicates 95% confidence that the true impact falls between $4.7 million and $8.5 million, meaning our estimate is likely conservative.

Super Sunday generated $296,155 in combined tax revenue. Sales tax contributed $174,801, calculated by applying Louisiana's 9.45% combined rate to 70% of spending. Hotel occupancy tax contributed $121,354, applying the 16.75% rate to estimated hotel bookings. We tested these numbers under various assumptions. Even if our spending estimates are 20% too high, Super Sunday still generates $261,000 in tax revenue—representing a strong positive return on public investment.

Post loyalty effects also exist, but are harder to measure with the given data, as non-local attendees are more likely to visit New Orleans and spend money as a result of enjoying their experience at Super Sunday.

Return on Investment

The 2025 event cost $70,000 to produce and generated $296,155 in tax revenue. The event generated tax revenue equal to 4.23 times total event cost. In other words, tax collections alone exceed public investment by more than fourfold. Every dollar invested generated approximately $60.40 in total economic activity. The event supports approximately 150 full-time equivalent jobs through direct and indirect effects. The cost per person reached is just $2.05.

Cost Efficiency and Comparative Analysis

We analyzed Super Sunday against other major New Orleans festivals. While each serves different purposes, the efficiency comparison is striking. Super Sunday costs $2.05 per attendee. French Quarter Fest costs $10.67 per attendee. Jazz Fest costs $30.77 per attendee. Essence Fest costs $33.33 per attendee. Super Sunday delivers comparable cultural value at 5 to 16 times lower cost per person than other major festivals. This efficiency stems from its community-driven model: thousands of volunteer hours, artists who prepare year-round without payment, and authentic participation rather than purchased entertainment.

For economic return on investment, Super Sunday generates a 60.4x return, very strong considering its size. French Quarter Fest generates 62.5x return. Jazz Fest generates 150x return as the highest due to its massive scale. Essence Fest generates 1.8x return.

For tax return specifically, Super Sunday ranks second only to Jazz Fest among major New Orleans cultural events. Jazz Fest generates a 9x tax return with $18 million in tax revenue, but operates at 30 times the budget scale. Super Sunday's 4.23x return, second in the city, demonstrates exceptional efficiency at a much smaller scale. French Quarter Fest generates 3.75x tax return.

Conclusion

Super Sunday represents something rare in public policy: compelling economics and cultural imperative aligned. The fiscal case stands on its own. A 323% tax ROI. Over $60 in economic activity per dollar invested. Based on available attendance figures and estimated event budgets for comparable festivals, Super Sunday demonstrates the lowest cost per attendee among major events analyzed.. Second-highest tax return among major festivals. Even conservative scenarios show strong positive returns.

The cultural case is equally compelling. A 200-year tradition that exists nowhere else. Serving underrepresented communities with free access. Creating genuine social cohesion. This analysis demonstrates that strategic public investment in Super Sunday yields measurable fiscal returns while preserving culturally significant heritage assets unique to New Orleans.

Appendix:

Data Sources

Primary data came from Placer.ai cell phone location tracking on March 16, 2025, Louisiana Cultural Economy Study for spending estimates, and peer-reviewed economic impact studies for multiplier effects. Metrics captured include total visits of 34,100 based on cell phone device counts, geographic origin through ZIP code analysis, dwell time averaging 108 minutes, and distance traveled through trade area coverage analysis.

Economic Impact Calculations

Direct spending was estimated using the formula: Local Visitors times Average Local Spending plus Non-Local Visitors times Average Non-Local Spending. Spending assumptions were $35 per person for local visitors covering food, beverages, and incidentals, and $125 per person for non-local visitors covering lodging, transport, food, and retail. These figures come from the Louisiana Cultural Economy Study, adjusted to 2025 dollars. The calculation yields 18,000 times $35 plus 16,100 times $125, equaling $630,000 plus $2,012,500, for a total of $2,642,500.

The economic multiplier of 1.6x was selected based on peer-reviewed studies of Louisiana cultural festivals showing multipliers ranging from 1.5x to 1.9x. We chose 1.6x to be conservative. This captures the direct effect of initial visitor spending at $2.64 million, indirect effects through business-to-business transactions with suppliers and vendors, and induced effects through employee income spent locally. Total economic impact equals direct spending times the multiplier, or $2,642,500 times 1.6, equaling $4,228,000.

Tax Revenue Calculations

Tax revenue calculations proceeded in two parts. For sales tax, the taxable base equals direct spending times 0.70, assuming 70% is taxable, yielding $1,849,750. Sales tax revenue equals the taxable base times 0.0945, the combined state and parish rate, yielding $174,801. For hotel occupancy tax, estimated hotel bookings equal non-local visitors times 0.30, assuming 30% book hotels, yielding 4,830 room nights. Hotel spending equals room nights times $150 per night, yielding $724,500. Hotel tax revenue equals hotel spending times 0.1675, the combined occupancy tax rate, yielding $121,354. Total tax revenue equals sales tax plus hotel tax, or $174,801 plus $121,354, equaling $296,155.

Statistical Significance Testing

We conducted a Welch's independent samples t-test, which does not assume equal variances, to test whether Super Sunday attendance differs from typical Sunday attendance. The result showed p less than 0.001, highly statistically significant, with less than 0.1% probability this difference occurred by chance. The standardized effect size was extraordinarily large, reflecting the substantial scale difference between typical Sunday attendance and Super Sunday attendance. This confirms that the event generates structurally distinct activity levels relative to normal baseline conditions.

Confidence Interval Analysis

Using bootstrap resampling with 1,000 iterations, we established statistical confidence bounds on the economic impact estimate. Resampling was conducted across direct spending inputs and multiplier assumptions to model uncertainty in total impact estimates. The 95% confidence interval ranges from $4,684,643 to $8,521,339. We are 95% confident the true economic impact falls within this range. The confidence interval reflects conservative spending and multiplier assumptions and indicates strong statistical confidence that total economic impact substantially exceeds the baseline direct spending estimate.

Sensitivity Analysis

We tested the robustness of conclusions under different assumptions by recalculating all metrics with plus or minus 20% spending adjustments. Under the conservative scenario with 20% lower spending, economic impact is $3,382,400, tax revenue is $261,195, and tax ROI is 273%. Under the base case, economic impact is $4,228,000, tax revenue is $296,155, and tax ROI is 323%. Under the optimistic scenario with 20% higher spending, economic impact is $5,073,600, tax revenue is $331,115, and tax ROI is 373%. The finding: even under conservative assumptions, positive tax ROI is maintained.

Regression Analysis

We validated the assumption that non-local visitors spend more using ordinary least squares regression with the model: Average Spending as a function of Distance Traveled. We conducted ordinary least squares regression at the ZIP-code level, modeling average estimated spending as a function of distance traveled. Results indicate that each additional mile traveled is associated with an average increase of $0.52 in per-capita spending ($p = 0.035$). The model explains 62% of variance in spending ($R^2 = 0.62$), supporting the assumption that non-local visitors contribute higher per-capita economic activity than local attendees.

Figure 1: Geographic Distribution of Super Sunday Attendees

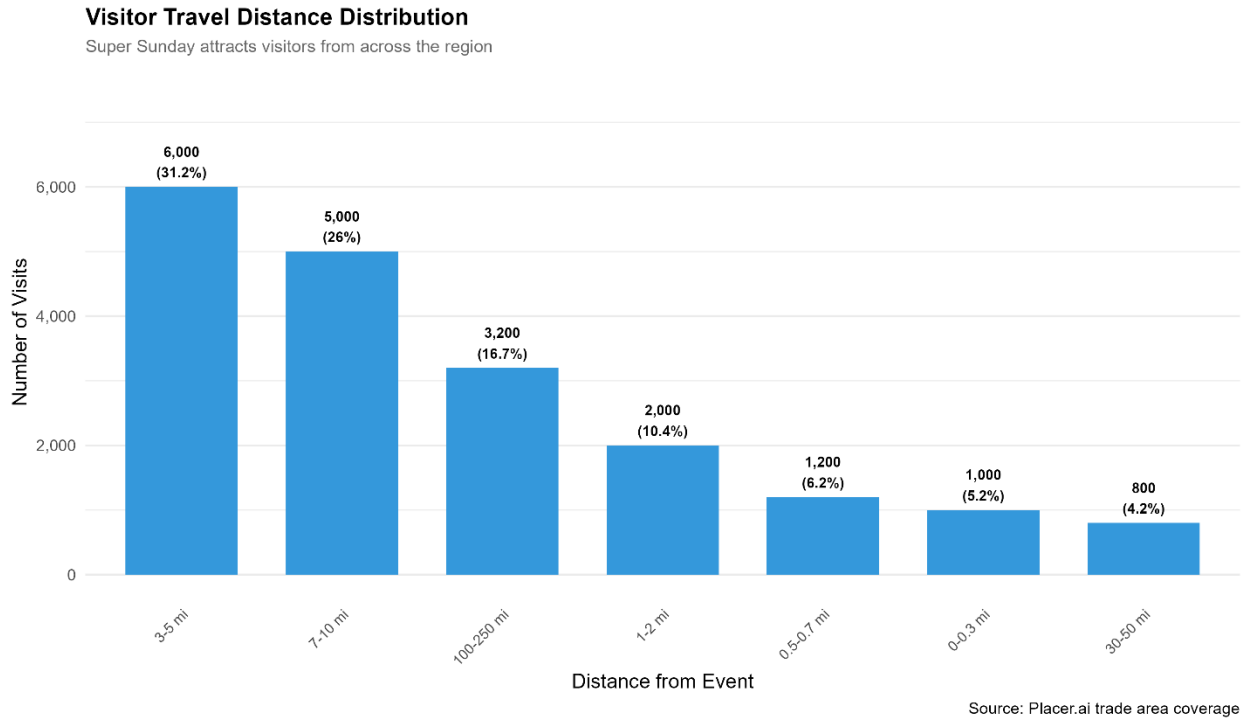
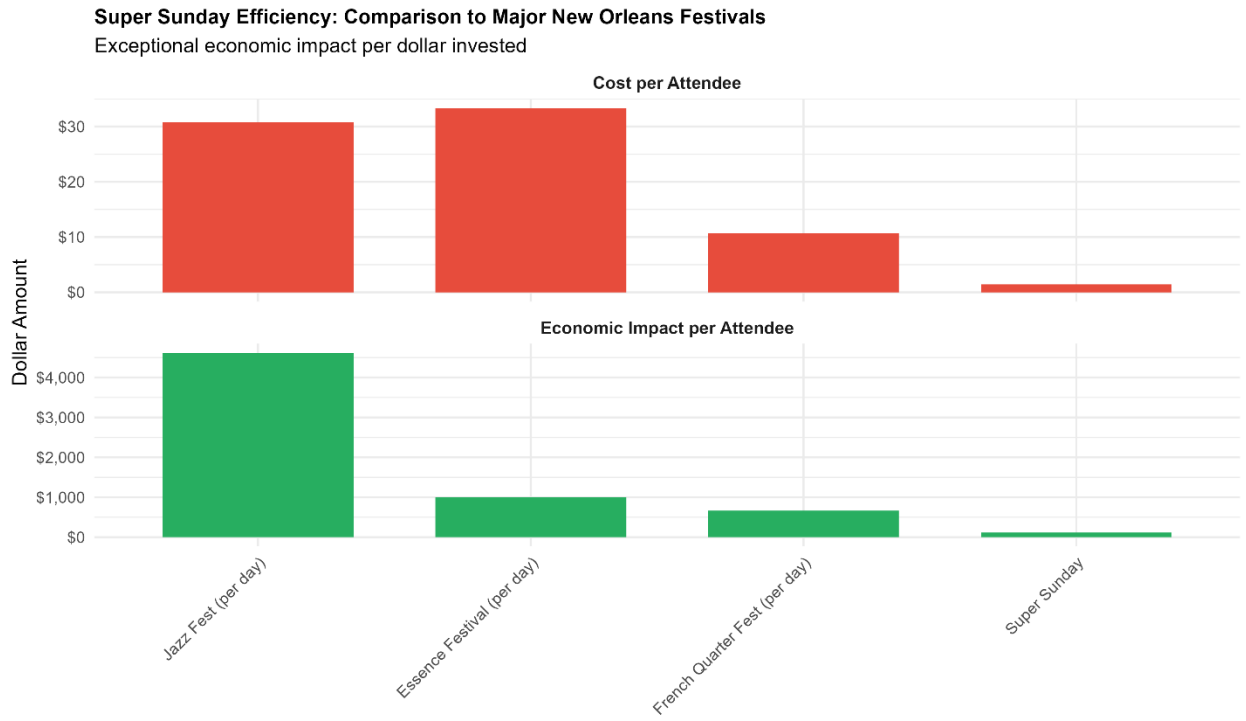


Figure 2: Fiscal ROI and Cost Efficiency Benchmarks



Benchmark Comparison Methodology

Data sources include published attendance figures from various sources, industry-standard budget estimates, and economic impact studies. Calculations are: Cost Per Attendee equals Event Budget divided by Total Attendance, Economic ROI equals Economic Impact divided by Event Budget, and Tax ROI equals Tax Revenue divided by Event Budget. Limitation: Other festivals' budgets are estimates based on comparable events. Super Sunday's figures are actual measurements.

Conservative Assumptions Throughout Analysis

We deliberately chose conservative estimates at every decision point. Spending rates use the lower end of published ranges. The economic multiplier of 1.6x compares to a typical range of 1.8 to 2.2x. The taxable percentage of 70% is likely lower than the actual rate. The hotel booking rate of 30% is conservative compared to possibly 40 to 50%. The hotel price of $150 per night is below New Orleans' average of $175-plus. Media value of $50,000 is conservative compared to likely $200,000-plus with proper calculation. The result: our estimates likely understate true economic impact.

Important Note

All economic impact estimates are derived using conservative assumptions grounded in peer-reviewed Louisiana cultural economy research and standard event-impact modeling methodologies. While multiplier-based modeling represents estimated rather than directly observed total transaction flows, sensitivity testing confirms that positive fiscal return is maintained under materially lower spending scenarios.